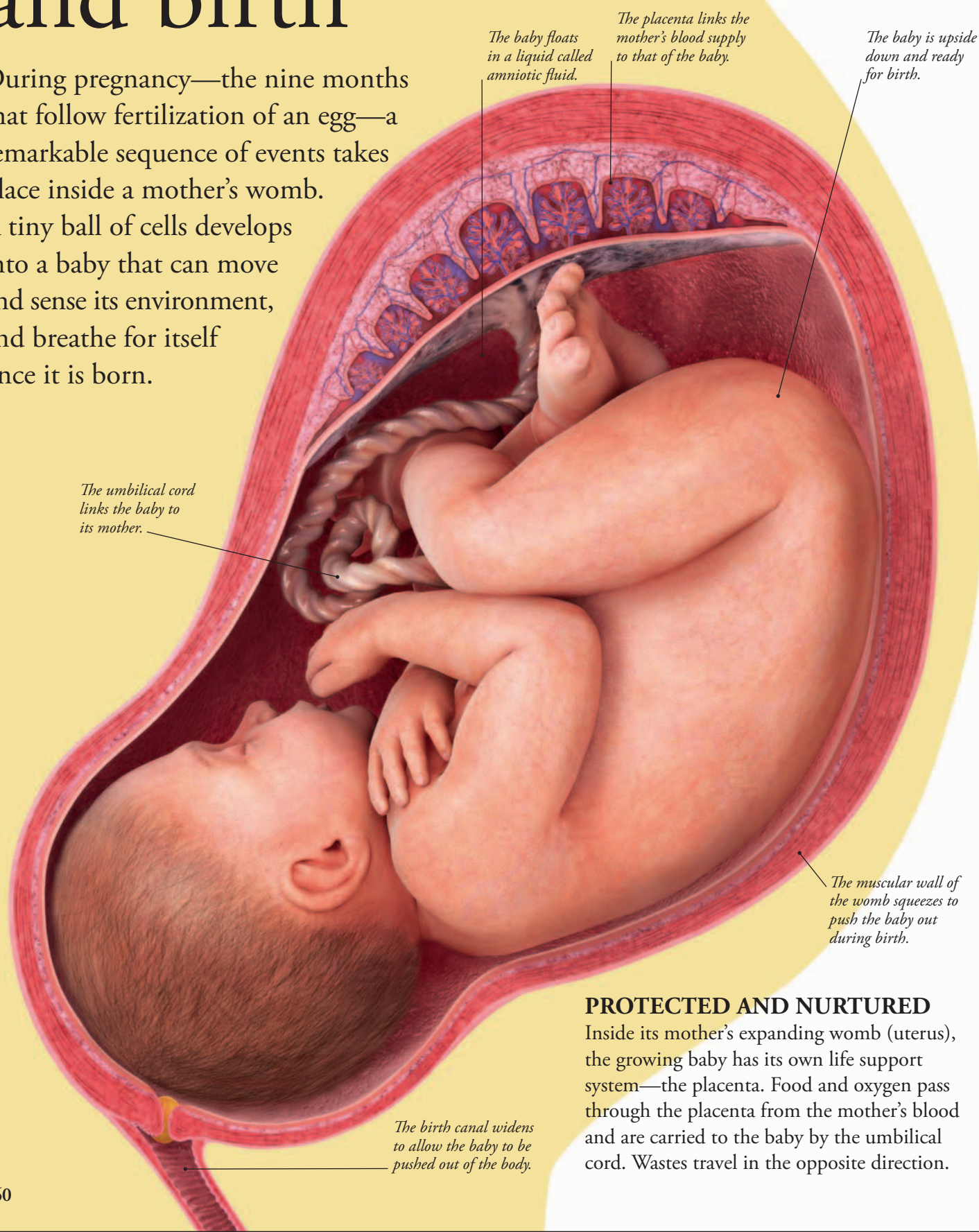


Pregnancy and birth

During pregnancy—the nine months that follow fertilization of an egg—a remarkable sequence of events takes place inside a mother's womb. A tiny ball of cells develops into a baby that can move and sense its environment, and breathe for itself once it is born.



PROTECTED AND NURTURED

Inside its mother's expanding womb (uterus), the growing baby has its own life support system—the placenta. Food and oxygen pass through the placenta from the mother's blood and are carried to the baby by the umbilical cord. Wastes travel in the opposite direction.